CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

GAME DESIGNER IN THE AI ERA

A third of the US industry was laid off in two years. The junior chairs were the first ones removed.

★ TL;DR — NO. There is no BLS occupation for game designers — no official median, no official outlook — and the market average of ~$100K (Indeed) describes people already inside. GDC's 2026 industry census found 33% of US game developers had been laid off in the previous two years, on top of roughly 45,000 industry jobs lost between 2022 and mid-2025. The roadmap below is the way OUT: the systems brain that designs games is worth real money in rooms that are still hiring. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

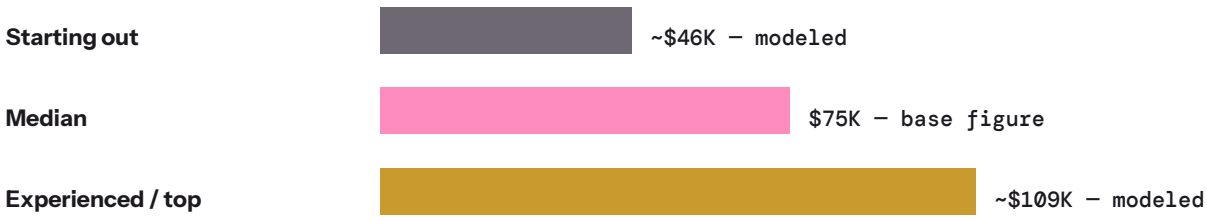
· Fails as a start because: the host industry is contracting, not pausing. GDC 2026: 28% of developers worldwide — 33% in the US — lost their jobs in two years; half said their current or most recent employer ran layoffs in the past 12 months; tracker counts put total losses near 45,000 jobs from 2022 to mid-2025.

· The exposure problem: the junior designer task list — design documentation, dialogue drafts, quest and content generation, balance spreadsheets — is precisely what the tools target. 52% of companies already report using generative AI, and design/narrative workers are the most negative discipline in the industry (63% unfavourable).

· Still worth money: systems thinking under feedback. Modelling economies, tuning difficulty from data, predicting how users exploit a rule set — that brain transfers directly into QA automation and data work growing at ~+6% and +35%.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Game Designer is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A GAME DESIGNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Design mechanics, levels, economies and progression systems
- ✓ Write the design documents the whole team builds from
- ✓ Prototype in an engine and tune balance from playtest data
- ✓ Watch players break your system in ways you never imagined — then fix it

Think: an architect of playgrounds with economies — designing rules for a building that's currently shedding a third of its staff.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
The junior production layer: art assets, dialogue drafts, quest and content variants, design documentation, balance modelling — with 52% of game companies already reporting generative AI use, prototyping and asset generation lead the list.	Game feel and player psychology: why a retry feels fair, where frustration becomes churn. Systems judgment earned by watching real players — the layer that transfers to every interactive product.

⚠ **THE $100K MIRAGE: the market average prices incumbents at surviving studios. Junior design postings cluster far lower and draw thousands of applicants each — students themselves told GDC their top concern is the lack of entry-level openings. An average is not a door.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ Systems, psychology and play — genuinely fascinating design problems ✓ Portfolio culture: playable proof beats credentials inside games ✓ Small teams of people who care absurdly much about the work	✗ An industry that shed ~45,000 jobs in three years — and kept shedding ✗ Crunch survives, cancellations survive, and entry pay lags other tech design roles ✗ Your favorite project can be cancelled after two years — and your chair with it

Good fit? You prototype compulsively and already think in data — loops, funnels, drop-off points. For you the exit is a translation, not a rescue: same brain, hiring industries.
Bad fit? You mainly want to be paid to have game ideas at a big studio. Nobody is — and right now barely anybody is being paid to execute them either.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO QA Engineer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Data Analyst
BLS Software Developers, Quality Assurance Analysts and Testers: the QA occupation line medians $104,300, with growth ~+6% occupation-specific (+10% for the OOH group), 2025–35. The version that hires is automation-first — the SDET: writing test systems, frameworks and CI pipelines, not clicking through checklists; manual testing is the automated layer. The bridge is real: designers already think in systems, edge cases and exploits — that is literally test design. First move: pick up a scripting language and automate the test cases for a game you built. That's a QA portfolio piece written in your native language.	Anchored to BLS Data Scientists: median $120,230, growth +35% — the fastest-growing anchor in this library. Honest label: there is no BLS 'Data Analyst' occupation; analysts enter below the scientist tier and the pay starts lower. What transfers is the part of game design nobody lists: telemetry. You have balanced economies from player data — funnels, retention curves, A/B reads. Every product company is short of people who can do that to business data. First move: publish one teardown of a game's economy using public data, charts and all. That's an analyst portfolio piece.

Smart move: If games stay the dream: enter sideways and know it — QA automation, programming, technical art, or ship an indie title (a business launch, not a hire). What no longer exists is the front door marked 'junior game designer' at a stable studio. The routes in are real; they're just not the title on this map.
Where you land after: You land where systems get built and measured: automating the tests that guard real software, or reading the data real products drown in. The design brain comes with you — pointed at industries that are hiring it.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	INVENTORY YOUR	LEARN TO	LEARN THE	SHIP ONE	APPLY AS

STEP 1 — Read the census, not the dream

FREE · TODAY

- Read the GDC 2026 numbers yourself: a third of the US workforce laid off in two years
- Your asset isn't the studio application — it's systems thinking plus data. That's what moves

STEP 2 — Inventory your systems reps

FREE · 1 WEEK

- List every system you designed, balanced or broke: economies, difficulty curves, progression
- Note the data you used each time — that column is an analyst résumé hiding in plain sight

STEP 3 — Learn to script

FREE · 2–4 WEEKS

- Python or C#: variables, loops, functions — enough to automate a test suite
- Automate the test cases for a game or mod you built; publish the repo

STEP 4 — Learn the QA-automation toolkit

SELF-PACED · 3–4 WEEKS

- Test frameworks, assertions, CI pipelines — the SDET stack, not manual checklists
- Frame your design experience as test design: edge cases are a designer's home turf

STEP 5 — Ship one data teardown

FREE · 2–3 WEEKS

- Take a live game's economy or a public dataset and produce a charted teardown
- It doubles as proof for Door B — two doors, one artifact

STEP 6 — Apply as an automation-first QA

FREE · ONGOING

- QA automation and SDET roles — in games and, pointedly, outside them; lead with the repo and the teardown
- Keep design warm with jams if you love it — as a portfolio hobby, not a rent plan

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the layoff numbers, then open a scripting tutorial. The second window is the career.

□ Days 1–30: scripting basics done; test automation started on your own game or mod.

□ Days 31–60: automation repo published; one data teardown written and posted.

□ Days 61–90: applications out to QA automation roles — or analyst roles if Door B wins.

□ Day 90: you're a systems thinker with code and charts on record — not applicant #4,000 for a junior design seat that may not exist.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **SYSTEMS OUTLIVE STUDIOS** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.